Uninor shutting services
The telecom operator Uninor has announced that it will shut down its operations in Kolkatta and West Bengal from January 18, 2013

Soyuz off to space
The Russian Soyuz spacecraft took off for the International Space Station for a two-day flight carrying a crew of three astronauts

Aakash: The complete story

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The vision behind the Aakash tablet is to bridge the digital divide in the country and help the students from rural and socio-economically weaker sections of the society to have access to modern technology and education.

Though the Aakash appears far away from mainstream tablets, but it is nevertheless important. For a country that has long grappled with a poor education system and no hope for rebuilding of the necessary infrastructure, the Aakash could play a key role in turning things around.

We need to empower our significantly large youth populace – most of them in the rural areas of the country –with quality and modern education. The tablet could very well play a key role in accomplishing it.

From Sakshat to Aakash

It all started back in 2011 when Union Minister of Human Resource Development, Kapil Sibal, announced an ambitious indigenous low-cost device that would be comparable to the One Laptop per Child (OLPC) initiative. While the OLPC initiative was aimed at rural and underprivileged students, the Indian government's device was initially intended for urban college students.

Still, not many people know that it wasn't the first time a 'Made in India' computer was coined. In early 2000, a prototype Simputer was produced in small numbers. Bangalore-based CPSU and Bharat Electronics Ltd even manufactured around 5,000 Simputers during 2002-07. In 2009, a number of states announced plans to order OLPCs. But then the project never took off.

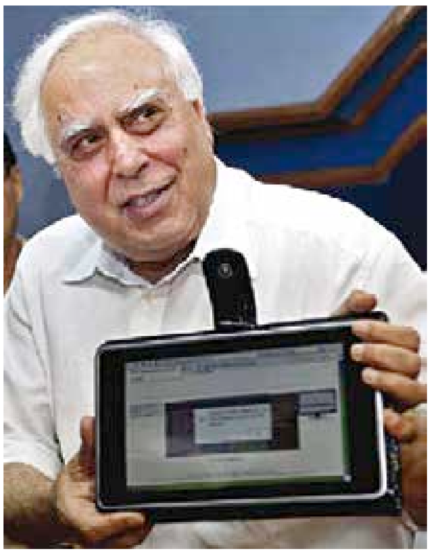
In July 2010, Kapil Sibal unveiled a prototype tablet, dubbed as the Sakshat. The price of the device showcased was projected at $35, which would eventually drop to $20 and ultimately to $10. After the device was exhibited, OLPC Chairman Nicholas Negroponte offered full access to OLPC technology to the Indian team for free.

While it seemed the country was set to deliver the world another masterpiece of innovation, the Sakshat project suffered its first blow when the company hired to build the Sakshat, HCL Infosystems, failed to prove that they had at least Rs. 60 crore in bank guaranteed funds, as mandated by the government. As a result, the government dropped HCL from the project and re-advertised the tender.

The Sakshat tender was then bagged by DataWind, a UK-based manufacturing and marketing company that produces wireless web access products, originally founded in Montreal.

Finally on October 5, 2011, Kapil Sibal unveiled the ultra low-cost tablet, called the Aakash. The device, earlier nicknamed as Sakshat, looked quite different from the prototype flaunted by the minister previous year. Again expectations ran high amid massive buzz in the country and even across the shores. DataWind went on to register pre-orders for the 1.4 million units of the UbiSlate 7 (commercial version of the Aakash) within just two weeks after releasing the device online.

But how many tablets were shipped? One of the first controversies that came to the light was the fall out between the government, DataWind and IIT-Rajasthan. The government was apparently unhappy with DataWind for trying to the sell the commercial version of the device before the government releasing the official Aakash tablet. DataWind also drew flak over the 'poor performance' of the device, as reported by IIT-Rajasthan. DataWind in its defence said IIT's test criteria didn't make sense, as it included conditions such



Kapil Sibal unveils the Aakash